and civil society and of the use of old knowledge and new research methods.

For every economic policy researcher or practitioner who feels exhausted at the thought of measurement in the problem before her—whether it is crime, courts, capital controls or air quality—the scale of work on the measurement of tigers is an inspiring story.

Principles for data release by the government

In previous years, the statistical system run by the government involved organizations which utilized a great deal of microeconomic data, that was kept secret, and released useful aggregate data. In the modern world, this can be reimagined. The most important role that the government can now play is to obtain and release micro data. The private sector will find diverse ways to utilize this as well.

As an example, in the old world, the Survey of India produced maps. The Survey of India conducted surveys, created internal data sets, and used these to create maps. In the modern world, the scarce resource is those large-scale survey data sets. The private sector is quite able to construct a variety of maps on its own. The role of the Survey of India thus needs to shift to building the public goods of maps data and releasing this database. Similar concepts apply for the Census of India.

Similarly, the government can release GDP data. It would be better to release all the underlying micro data that is used to compute GDP. After that, different users will process this data in different ways and form their own picture about what is going on in the economy.

Two useful principles to think about data release are:

1. If something can be obtained using the Right to Information (RTI) Act, it should be released pre-emptively. We should progressively expand the scope of items under ‘duty to publish’ of the RTI Act.